those overrides were eliminated entirely. Similarly, finance teams removed special access lists after shared policies captured reporting access rules across systems.

Over time, ACME tracked progress by observing a steady decline in exception-related changes and emergency access procedures. Fewer one-off rules led to fewer surprises in authorization behavior and reduced opportunities for policy drift. For Sam, this decrease was one of the clearest signs that Zero Trust had moved beyond just theory. Instead of depending on fragile, undocumented workarounds, ACME's teams increasingly trusted the policy system to accurately reflect and enforce the access decisions the organization genuinely needed.

As figure 15.5 illustrates, progress toward Zero Trust isn't a ladder to climb but a set of architectural dimensions to develop over time. By improving policy coverage, signal quality, and decision consistency, reducing reliance on the perimeter, and eliminating ad hoc authorization exceptions, ACME built a security architecture where Zero Trust was not just a goal but an actionable strategy based on greater reliance on policy-based access decisions.

15.6 Beyond security: the organizational payoff

As ACME's zero-trust security architecture took shape, Sam expected enhancements in access control, auditability, and incident response. What he hadn't fully anticipated was how far the benefits would extend beyond the security team. By basing access control on clear policies assessed against high-quality signals, ACME not only boosted its defenses but also improved its operational, collaborative, and innovative capabilities. Zero Trust evolved into more than just a security strategy; it became a foundational architecture that enhanced the way the entire company worked.

15.6.1 Better alignment between teams

One of the earliest benefits was a change in how teams worked together. Before PBAC, authorization logic was spread across applications, CI/CD pipelines, and operations tools, leading to minor differences in how systems